

FROM ONE TO MANY: INDIA'S PARALYMPIC ODYSSEY

From Murlikant Petkar's lone gold in 1972 to **a record 29 medals** at Paris 2024, India's Paralympic journey is a story of grit, growth, and a sporting revolution.

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1968

From Lone Swimmer to Record Haul: The Rise of Indian Parasport

When 10 Indians turned up in Tel Aviv for the 1968 Paralympics, they carried little more than determination. There were no systems, no sponsors, and no real blueprint for success. They returned without medals, but with the first tentative steps in a journey that would one day transform India's place in global parasport. Fast forward to Paris 2024: an 84-member contingent delivered a record 29 medals. The distance between those two moments captures the remarkable evolution of Indian parasport.

1968-1984

The Lonely Pioneers

India's first Paralympic appearance came in 1968, but medals would have to wait. Four years later, one man changed that. Murlikant Petkar, who had travelled to Tel Aviv as a table tennis player, returned in Heidelberg as a swimmer and scripted history. His gold in the 50m freestyle, achieved with a world record of 37.33 seconds, made him India's first Paralympic medallist.

Yet Petkar remained a solitary beacon. India skipped the 1976 and 1980 Games, returning only in 1984 — when Joginder Singh Bedi made history with three medals, across shot put, javelin, and discus, becoming the first Indian para-athlete to win multiple medals at a single edition. Bhimrao Kesarkar added another. For a moment, it seemed a corner had been turned. Instead, the next two decades yielded only drought.



1988-2000

Flickers of Progress

Through the late 20th century, India's Paralympic presence was modest but persistent. From two athletes in Seoul 1988 to a high of nine in Barcelona and Atlanta, before shrinking to four in Sydney 2000, the teams returned without medals — yet in those years, participation itself was the small victory that kept the flame alive.